

Periodic reminder that running an AI on a local machine uses the same electricity as running a video game

Posted by u/Kirbyoto • 0 points • 66 comments

Inspired by a user who claimed that this was "an absolutely ridiculous, completely unfounded claim that compares normal user activity to someone so deeply invested in using AI that they are running entire local machines dedicated to it". It's a free executable that anyone can download. The image in the OP took 15 seconds of regular computing power to produce.

Comments

u/HelpRespawnedAsDee • 1 points • 2026-03-08 01:39 UTC

well yeah, you are essentially maxing out the most power hungry component in both cases.

u/billjames1685 • 0 points • 2026-03-07 23:38 UTC

Fun reminder that non local AI is almost always more efficient per capita than local AI (depending on the models run)! Data centers are built to efficiently process millions of queries; there's no way a local machine could be more efficient.

u/SweetCommieTears • 2 points • 2026-03-07 10:36 UTC

If antis knew anything about what they moan about, they wouldn't be antis.

u/LadyQuacklin • 1 points • 2026-03-07 08:34 UTC

<https://preview.redd.it/0wuzpqn24lng1.png?width=685&format=png&auto=webp&s=50ef0a60e0cc8efec50f81c37697949380e34ed6>

u/LadyQuacklin • 2 points • 2026-03-07 08:33 UTC

<https://preview.redd.it/xasv8cwv3lng1.png?width=685&format=png&auto=webp&s=6202ed14c05ab70072697abeb709ec0bb50c7455>

u/trexmaster8242 • 2 points • 2026-03-07 07:11 UTC

When people say that they're referring to training costs but mainly the cost it takes to train run and maintain an LLM, which is enormous.

u/Kirbyoto • 3 points • 2026-03-07 21:23 UTC

First off, no, that's not what they're referring to. Otherwise individual consumers would not be blamed as if every image they produce is meaningfully adding to the total cost.

Secondly, it takes hundreds of hours of rendering to make a few frames of CGI in a modern movie. But when you play the finished product, are you using that energy again? No, it's just a movie now. The initial cost of production does not get added to by playback.

u/trexmaster8242 • 1 points • 2026-03-07 22:13 UTC

There are data centers they are building to be a large chunk the size of manhattan. Those data centers are that big so they can host frontier model LLMs. That takes lots of power to use train and query. This is what people refer to.

A simple neural net your running locally isn't much but these frontier models are a lot more complex.

It's like someone complained about gas guzzling trucks and then you whip out a small kid motorcycle that needs some gas as a defence saying trucks don't guzzle gas

u/Kirbyoto • 1 points • 2026-03-11 19:45 UTC

>This is what people refer to.

Outside of AI, individuals are not responsible for the behavior of corporations. You personally are not held responsible for the cost of keeping Reddit or Youtube online even though you use both those websites. Also based on what I can accomplish with my computer alone I doubt most AI services commonly used by consumers (i.e. not business-facing) are much more of a drain.

>It's like someone complained about gas guzzling trucks and then you whip out a small kid motorcycle that needs some gas as a defence saying trucks don't guzzle gas

No it's like if someone said "all vehicles are the same" and then treated an e-bike the same as a dump truck. They aren't complaining about "gas guzzling trucks" because that would require them to be able to differentiate one type of AI from another and they don't know or care to do so.

u/YoureCorrectUProle • 3 points • 2026-03-07 13:02 UTC

Training takes a lot of power, yes. Running a LLM locally doesn't take much power, though. I can run one off my home PC and that just has a consumer grass 4000 series GPU in it.

u/Ram_249 • 3 points • 2026-03-07 07:41 UTC

my 5080 says otherwise